

AUDIOBOOK STUDY COMPANION

The Sales Coach's Playbook

Breaking the Performance Code

BILL BARTLETT

Foreword by David Mattson · A Sandler Training Audiobook

OUTLINE · ACTION GUIDE · QUICK REFERENCE

Eleven chapters. The complete Sandler coaching system.

INSIDE THIS COMPANION

Eleven chapters.

The complete Sandler coaching system, chapter by chapter.

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PART II — THE ACTION GUIDE

After the chapter outlines, Bartlett's wisdom is reorganized into a working action guide built around the lifecycle of a coaching session: **Assess** before the first one, **Engage** inside every session, and **Sustain** across the long arc. The book closes with a Quick Reference — one principle per chapter, designed to print and pin.

01

The Basics

What coaching is — and what it isn't

00:05:46

"Effective sales coaching is not showing them how to do it."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Barb's company. Founder Barb caught lightning in a bottle, then hit a wall in year four. Her instinct was to push harder and tell salespeople exactly what to do — Barb-style. After top performers quit under the pressure, weekly coaching helped her separate coaching from supervising and rebuild the team.

The Sandler Submarine. Bartlett anchors coaching in the seven Sandler steps — bonding & rapport, upfront contracts, pain, budget, decision, fulfillment, post-sell — and reminds coaches the salesperson can only be coached at their actual level today, not the level the coach wishes they were at.

Gold, silver, bronze trust. Three measurable levels of trust in the coaching relationship. Gold is built over time and unlocks the openness real growth requires; bronze is the starting point. The coach's job is to move every relationship up the ladder.

THE CORE LESSON

Coaching is a formal, ongoing one-on-one process that helps salespeople discover better ways to act — not a hallway pep talk and not a session where the manager fixes problems.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Benchmark the salesperson's current skill before coaching begins; coach to that level, not the future one.
 2. Coaching is roughly 35% of the leadership role — supervising, mentoring, and training are the other three.
 3. Every session opens with two assessments — the salesperson's self-assessment and the coach's coaching assessment — and a clear upfront contract.
 4. Coaching is a marathon, not a sprint; consistent fortnightly sessions beat one heroic intervention.
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02

Developing the Coach's Mindset

Seek first to understand

00:51:00

"The coach's job is to help salespeople become the best possible version of themselves."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Alex's perpetual pipeline. Alex's prospects never closed; manager Kiko wanted him sent to closing training. Bartlett saw the real issue — a middle child with a high need for approval who read any disagreement as conflict — and used a doctor-patient analogy to reframe selling as diagnosis.

Stephen Covey's fifth habit. Habit five — seek first to understand — is the single sentence Bartlett would boil this entire book down to. Effective coaches study the salesperson as a person before touching the role.

Self-worth = identity + role. Sandler's foundational equation. Identity is who you are; role is what you do. Coaches who only work the role miss the leverage point — belief in self is what makes role change possible.

THE CORE LESSON

The coach's mindset is curious, patient, and non-judgmental — focused on understanding the depth of the salesperson's issues before attempting any behavior change.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Cultivate the nine coach attributes: self-awareness, balanced focus, problem-solving, sincere interest, nurturing feedback, strategic thinking, openness, trustworthiness, and questioning skills.
2. Protect identity while you improve role — both must stay strong for performance to compound.
3. Use the rule of three and two: three professional goals plus two personal goals each week, so identity and role grow together.
4. Rate each of the top 10 selling behaviors 1–10, then apply more, better, or different to lift execution.

03

Dealing with Change

Comfort kills performance

01:24:14

"Growth and high performance reside on the other side of comfort."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Diego, 5 of 400. Bartlett disqualifies salespeople from his President's Club training when they fail the entry assessment. Of 400 disqualified over the years, only five pushed back and committed to change. Diego was one of them — he rose from 50th of 100 salespeople to number three.

Sarah changes the rules. Sarah had gone 45 days without a sale. By reframing selling as a chess game with rules she controlled — and treating rejection as the opponent breaking the rules — she turned around her phone presence in 20 days.

Kübler-Ross, translated. Bartlett adapts the five stages of grief into four coaching transitions: denial, resistance, exploration, commitment. Most coaching fails because the coach starts at exploration while the salesperson is still in denial.

THE CORE LESSON

Salespeople change only when the pain of staying the same is greater than the pain of changing — and even then, the transition runs through four stages, not a switch.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Coach through denial and resistance before reaching for exploration; meet people where they actually are.
2. Use the Success Triangle — behavior, attitude, technique — as the cornerstone of every coaching session.
3. Apply the 20-60-20 rule: nurture the top 20, build traction with the middle 60, demand proof from the bottom 20.
4. Teach the four-step process for replacing persistent negative thoughts: name it, flip it, visualize it, execute it for 20 straight days.

04

Take the X-Ray

Goals drive coaching

01:50:20

"Goals without plans are daydreams."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Peter the steady eddy. A mid-career top performer plateaued and was being eclipsed by younger reps. Small professional goals plus personal goals — eating right, exercising — rebuilt confidence over two years until Peter was the sales leader again.

Rick's bonding problem. A 10-year veteran knew NLP and upfront contracts cold but his sales were stalling. A coaching role-play surfaced that his vocal tonality was sharp and dominating; dropping half an octave and acting a little 'not-okay' opened prospects up.

The Divine Inventory & Extended DISC. Two assessment tools used by Sandler franchisees to surface hidden traits — Michelle's broken 'sales motor' (goal setting, vitality, ego, time, initiative) and Tom's steamrolling DISC profile both came to light through assessment.

THE CORE LESSON

Effective coaching starts with a sales X-ray — vision, mission, strategy, goals, plus an honest as-is to be-gap analysis of skill, knowledge, and application.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Help each salesperson articulate vision, mission, strategy, and SMART goals before working on tactics.
2. Use the as-is to be-growth gap to benchmark current skill levels and set time-bound improvement targets.
3. Separate skills (what they know), knowledge (when to use it), and application (whether they actually do).
4. Invest coaching time in salespeople unconditionally committed to growth — not the bottom 20 percent giving lip service.

05

Building Trust and Comfort

The three Ps and the well-better partnership

02:24:41

"Without trust, effective sales coaching is impossible."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Jill's 369 cold calls. Three weeks, 369 calls, zero sales. Role failure had collapsed into identity failure. Bartlett split them back apart with two parallel growth tracks — exercise, reading, date nights to rebuild identity while skills got sharper — and Jill recovered in three weeks.

Stephanie and the professional services rule. Stephanie believed she couldn't close professional services prospects because she lacked the education they had. Working at the core-belief level — rewriting the rule from 'I can't close them' to 'I'm a sales professional with the skill to help any client' — fixed what skills training couldn't.

Bagger Vance's caddy line. From the film: 'The war is over. It's time to put the baggage down and keep walking.' Bartlett uses this as the coach's mandate — help salespeople unpack the head trash before it accumulates.

THE CORE LESSON

Trust is built through a formal coaching contract that establishes the three Ps — potency, permission, protection — and a well-better partnership that grows identity alongside role.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Build every session on a strong coaching contract — goals, time, agenda, methodology, environment, actions.
 2. Take your sales-manager hat off; flatten potency so the salesperson can speak freely without reprisal.
 3. Read tonality and body language for leakage when words and signals don't match.
 4. Stay in the nurturing parent and non-judgmental adult ego states — never the critical parent or wanting child.
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06

Coaching — A Process, Not an Event

The seven-step Sandler Coaching System

02:53:41

"You can't coach someone in a 30-second conversation in a hallway."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Luis on the sales floor. A new-breed manager of 50 millennial inside reps thought he was coaching by patrolling the floor and solving problems on the fly. One question — 'How would you handle this if I weren't here?' — gave him 40 percent of his work week back and let his people grow.

Aaliyah plays the movie. After a disastrous call, Aaliyah and her manager Vincent slowed the call down frame by frame in a quiet conference room. A weak upfront contract was the root cause — invisible at full speed, obvious in slow motion.

Carrie's intuitive coaching. A manager who had cobbled together coaching ideas from books and trusted her intuition kept hitting dead ends. The seven-step Sandler system gave her the structure she'd been missing — assess, set growth goals, define new behavior, execute, review, modify, evaluate.

THE CORE LESSON

Coaching is a structured seven-step system — not a casual conversation. Each step builds on the previous one, and the loop runs continuously.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Run both strategic coaching (planning for future issues) and tactical coaching (executing current skills) — strategy first, tactics second.
2. Schedule sessions for 30 uninterrupted minutes in a private space; never less than 15.
3. Follow the seven steps in order: assess, set goals, define new behavior, execute for 20 days, review, modify, evaluate.
4. Encourage self-coaching and peer-to-peer coaching to accelerate growth and scale your reach.

07

Understanding Salespeople

The why behind the behavior

03:27:19

"Behavior without why is intellectual and ineffective."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Sophia's wrong assumption. A Fortune 1000 CEO assumed her sales force showed up for money and recognition because that's what motivated her. An anonymous survey revealed that 65 percent showed up for security. The motivators that drive you don't necessarily drive your team.

Mike vs. Santiago. Two salespeople at the same company faced the same threat: produce or be fired. Mike said the right things, slipped back, and was terminated in 45 days. Santiago built small goals over 20 days, locked the changes in, and kept his job. Motivation alone isn't enough — it has to turn into habit.

Skyler's pain questions. Skyler asked the right Sandler pain questions but watered them down so prospects wouldn't dislike her. The fix wasn't more training — it was an internal inventory that surfaced a deep-seated need for approval.

THE CORE LESSON

Each salesperson has a personal why that drives their behavior, and a unique mix of assets and liabilities that the coach has to learn to read.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Use the five whys to peel back to the root cause of every issue.
2. Recognize the four sales personalities — self-taught, renegade, player, continuous learner — and adjust your style for each.
3. Turn motivation into habit; motivation starts success, habit sustains it.
4. Inventory the five key assets (awareness, goals, structure, thinking, time) and five key liabilities (need for approval, outlook, emotion, fear of rejection, ego).

08

The Coach's Toolbox

Questions, feedback, and the loop

04:00:26

"The salesperson is only growing when responding — not when the coach is talking."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Milt does all the talking. While shadowing Milt's session with Jordan, Bartlett noticed Milt was talking, assuming, and prescribing — not coaching. Replaying the session and inserting Sandler questioning strategies revealed Jordan was running the system intellectually without engaging on a personal level.

Carlos and the enterprise template. A successful rep promoted to enterprise accounts started losing deals because he ran a small-account playbook in big-account meetings. The feedback loop — Carlos's view, coach's view, awareness gap, real-time understanding, ownership — produced a seven-step, 45-day enterprise template.

The Sandler coaching funnel. Ten coaching questions that move the salesperson from intellectual discussion to emotional commitment — what's the goal, what's driving it, what's been tried, what's blocking it, how committed are you, what benefits you, what action can you take now, how can the coach help.

THE CORE LESSON

Effective coaching draws on a stocked toolbox — active listening, the dummy curve, striplining, reversing — plus a five-stage feedback loop and a discipline of journaling.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Practice the four questioning strategies before every session: active listening, the dummy curve, striplining, reversing.
 2. Aim for the 70-30 split — the salesperson talks 70 percent, the coach asks the 30.
 3. Use 'but' carefully — it's a fact eraser that wipes the praise you just gave; replace with 'and' wherever possible.
 4. Bookend each day with journaling — morning intentions plus evening debrief — and review every 20 days to spot patterns.
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09

Thoughts Influence Performance

Mind your self-talk

04:38:50

"Your beliefs become your thoughts. Your thoughts become your words. Your habits become your destiny."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Nadir's father in the field. After years of success, Nadir's sales plateaued — driven by his father's old warnings that wealthy people are immoral. The fix was less about money and more about purpose: contributing to a breast cancer foundation and the Special Olympics gave his wealth a meaning that bypassed the limiting belief.

Amy and the bad-time opener. Amy's cold calling spiraled because she expected each call to fail. Switching her opener from 'Is this a good time?' to 'Have I caught you at a bad time?' got her to a yes early and changed the entire arc of the call. Inside 20 days she went from 3 conversations a day to 15.

Bartlett's golf driver. Bartlett struggled with his driver until his coach Chris taught him a pre-shot visualization routine — grip, feet, posture, target lock. Driver accuracy improved 70 percent. He now uses an identical pre-shot routine before sales calls.

THE CORE LESSON

Performance is governed by self-talk; up to 70 percent of our thoughts are negative, and coaches who don't address thought patterns are coaching around the real problem.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Catch negative self-talk early — high performers control their thoughts; low performers are controlled by them.
2. Use creative visualization daily: see the outcome, hear what people say about it, feel what it produces inside.
3. Build mental toughness through perfect practice — gloves-off role plays in real-world conditions, debriefed afterward.
4. Train salespeople the way coaches train athletes: practice, game-day execution, film review, repeat.

10

Becoming a High-Performance Coach

Walking the tightrope

05:03:00

"The primary function of the coach is to develop salespeople — not rescue them."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Kayla's slumping book. A top performer lost four anchor clients in six months and stopped prospecting. Her manager Meredith rebuilt trust using the three Ps, then layered in networking, referrals, and business introductions on a 90-day arc. Kayla returned to top-performer status with a redesigned cookbook.

Jasmine and Susan's 'do-you-have-a-minute?' Jasmine cared more about Susan's success than Susan did. By only scheduling new sessions after Susan executed homework, Jasmine moved ownership back across the desk — and freed up time for the rest of her team.

The behavioral dashboard. Five weekly metrics — number of suspects, first face-to-face meetings, active qualified proposals, close-the-sale meetings, prospecting hours — give a coach real-time signal to address problems while they're small.

THE CORE LESSON

High-performance coaching is built on a personalized GPS for each salesperson, hard behavioral standards, ongoing learning, and the discipline of staying off the salesperson's side of the desk.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Customize a coaching guidance system per salesperson — relationship, goals, communication style, methodology.
 2. Raise the performance bar with concrete behavioral metrics, then track them weekly to catch slippage early.
 3. Watch for coaching transference — the moment you start working harder on their success than they do.
 4. Keep your own coaching journal on each salesperson; review every 90 days to refresh your approach.
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11

Moving Forward

The Sandler change triangle

05:30:25

"Working on who you are is as important as working on what you do."

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

David's Chamber of Commerce slump. A young rep got a quick lift from a one-day Chamber sales class, then stalled at three weeks. Real coaching plus weekly Sandler workshops moved him to the top five of his 100-person sales force inside a year — the combination of training and coaching, not either alone.

Connor's plateau. An award-winning veteran sensed he'd plateaued and asked his manager Jesse for the next gear. The Change Triangle — capacity, capability, competency — surfaced exactly what to expect, what attitudes to test, and where skill execution had to climb from silver to gold.

Ten best practices. Bartlett's closing checklist — process not event, integrated into culture, personal accountability, no called-to-the-principal's-office feel, full assessment, no fix-first reflex, no winging it, address identity and role, build self-coaching, stick to the facts.

THE CORE LESSON

The Sandler Coaching System closes the success gap by raising capacity (room to grow), capability (willingness to change), and competency (skill execution) — and the coach needs a coach too.

BARTLETT'S TAKEAWAYS

1. Customize the coaching model and personalize every solution — there is no one-size-fits-all.
 2. Build the right mix of supervisor, mentor, trainer, and coach in your leadership style — about 35 percent should be coaching.
 3. Embed sales coaching into the company culture as a key driver of success, not a punitive correction.
 4. Use the Sandler Change Triangle — capacity, capability, competency — as the blueprint for long-term growth.
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PART II

THE ACTION GUIDE

*Bartlett's coaching wisdom, reorganized around the lifecycle of a session:
Assess before the first one, **Engage** inside every session, and **Sustain** across
the 90-day arc.*

PHASE · ASSESS

Assess

Before the first coaching session

Benchmark the top 10 behaviors

Rate this salesperson 1–10 on lead generation, building relationships, qualifying, presenting, servicing, account management, territory development, cookbook, continuous education, and Sandler execution. Any score below 7 is a training issue, not a coaching one.

Run a behavioral assessment

Use the Divine Inventory or Extended DISC to surface internal motivators, blind spots, and communication style. You can't coach what you can't see — and assessments expose what observation can't.

Conduct an as-is to be-gap analysis

Where are they today on each priority skill? Where do they need to be? What's the time frame? The growth gap becomes the roadmap for the next 90 days.

Identify the four-type fit

Self-taught, renegade, player, or continuous learner? Each personality needs a different coaching approach — knowing the type before you sit down saves three sessions of trial and error.

Lock in their why

Use the five whys to drill past the surface goal to the personal reason this salesperson needs to change. Without the why, every behavior plan is intellectual and won't survive contact with reality.

Place them on the 20-60-20 map

Top 20 needs nurturing and recognition. Middle 60 needs small wins to build traction. Bottom 20 needs to prove they're worthy of your coaching time before you invest it.

PHASE · ENGAGE

Engage

Inside every coaching session

Set the coaching contract

Six elements: goals, time, agenda, methodology, environment, and follow-up actions. Without it, the session drifts. With it, both sides know what success looks like before the conversation starts.

Establish the three Ps of trust

Potency (take the manager hat off), permission (speak freely), protection (no reprisal). Trust is the gateway to vulnerability, and vulnerability is the gateway to real change.

Open with well-better

Begin every session with three things the salesperson did well in their last sales call. The positive opening protects identity and lets you address role honestly without the conversation feeling punitive.

Run the seven-step Sandler system

Assess current status, set growth goals, define new behavior, execute for 20 days, review progress, modify, evaluate. Follow it in order — each step depends on the one before.

Work the four questioning strategies

Active listening to hear what's actually being said. The dummy curve to keep them talking. Striplining to disarm. Reversing to dig deeper. The salesperson should be doing 70 percent of the talking.

Play the movie

When debriefing a sales call, slow it down frame by frame. Ask 'then what happened?' and 'tell me more' until the missed details surface. Speed hides the problem; slow motion reveals it.

Close with action steps

Every session ends with specific, measurable behaviors the salesperson commits to executing for the next 20 days. Coaching without action is conversation.

PHASE · SUSTAIN

Sustain

Between sessions and over the long arc

Establish a 20-day execution cycle

New behaviors need 20 consecutive days to imprint. Most people quit at 13 when the initial discomfort peaks — set the expectation up front so the salesperson pushes through the wall.

Keep two journals running

The salesperson's daily journal — morning intentions, evening debrief — and your own coaching journal on each rep. Review the salesperson's at day 20; review yours every 90 days.

Track the behavioral dashboard

Suspects, first face-to-faces, qualified proposals, close-the-sale meetings, prospecting hours. Weekly metrics surface small problems before they become chronic ones.

Apply more, better, different

When behavior isn't producing results, ask which lever to pull — more of the same behavior, better execution of it, or a completely different approach. This puts the salesperson in control of their own diagnosis.

Schedule the cadence

Coaching every two weeks at minimum. Skip the cadence and you lose the velocity of change — each session should build on the previous one, not start from scratch.

Audit the change triangle every 90 days

Capacity (what they can realistically grow), capability (their willingness to change), competency (their actual skill execution). All three need attention; ignoring any one of them stalls progress.

Get your own coach

Bartlett ends the book with this: every coach needs a coach. The skill set degrades without external pressure to grow. Find someone above your level and book a regular session.

QUICK REFERENCE

One principle per chapter.

Print this page. Pin it. Glance at it before every coaching session.

01 THE BASICS

Coaching is a structured process, not a hallway pep talk — and it's roughly 35% of effective sales leadership.

02 THE COACH'S MINDSET

Seek first to understand the salesperson as a person; identity and role must both be coached.

03 DEALING WITH CHANGE

Salespeople change only when the pain of staying the same exceeds the pain of changing — and that runs through four stages.

04 TAKE THE X-RAY

Goals drive coaching; without a vision-mission-strategy-goals stack and a gap analysis, you're flying blind.

05 BUILDING TRUST

The three Ps — potency, permission, protection — turn a coaching session into a place real growth can happen.

06 THE PROCESS

Follow the seven-step Sandler Coaching System in order; coaching on the fly isn't coaching.

07 UNDERSTANDING SALESPEOPLE

Every salesperson has a personal why — and what motivates you probably doesn't motivate them.

08 THE TOOLBOX

Active listening, dummy curve, striplining, reversing — and the feedback loop that turns conversation into commitment.

09 THOUGHTS DRIVE PERFORMANCE

Up to 70% of internal self-talk is negative; coach the thought patterns or you're coaching around the real problem.

10 HIGH-PERFORMANCE COACHING

Stay off the salesperson's side of the desk — your job is to develop them, not rescue them.

11 MOVING FORWARD

Capacity, capability, competency — the Sandler Change Triangle is the long-game blueprint.

"Every coach needs a coach." — Bill Bartlett